



RAMALINGA RAJU WITH WIFE NANDINI (LEFT); WITH EMPLOYEES AT SATYAM TECHNOLOGY CENTRE IN HYDERABAD

It made him an icon, revered more than any politician or Tollywood star in his native state. To them, he was a job creator as much as a wealth creator. He became a people's hero by his simplicity, often wearing the light blue shirt with the Satyam logo like other employees whom he called Satyamites. He was an adept networker attending conferences and conventions and a voracious reader of management books. From this sprang many ideas that he introduced with the sole objective of building brand Satyam.

Part of this strategy was to cultivate politicians in power. He practised this across the political spectrum, most notably with N. Chandrababu Naidu, then chief minister. Raju convinced Naidu to visit Davos to attract investments, one of the first chief ministers to do so. In return, Naidu gave Raju pride of place when dignitaries came calling, including Bill Clinton and Bill Gates. Their relationship worked for Raju when the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence probed Satyam's accounts in 2002-03. Naidu's intervention helped avert an inquiry that could have been embarrassing for both.

No less impressed about Raju's enterprise was Naidu's successor, Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, who agreed to a public-private partnership model in funding a state-wide ambulance service. Reddy agreed to provide 95 per cent of the costs for running the network of the Emergency Management Research Institute launched with funding from Raju. By now, Raju was earning a string of awards, Indian and international, but cracks were starting to show. He made Satyam a family-controlled concern, though not all family members agreed with the changes. D. Venkata Suryanarayana Raju left, opposing some investments in Satyam Constructions in 1992.

Traditionally, the Rajus do not involve women in business and sons are not allowed to take independent decisions. His wife Nandini and sons Teja and Rama keep a low profile.

Even their rare interactions with the media have been with the approval of Ramalinga. Nandini is involved in an advisory capacity with a couple of charities but the husband was the only public face of Satyam. "My biggest discovery in life is that there is a tremendous opportunity to demystify knowledge and that ordinary people can do extraordinary things," he told INDIA TODAY during a conversation in his well-stocked library overlooking a well-manicured lawn at his sprawling Hyderabad home less than a year ago.

Sadly, in what Chief Minister Reddy described as "greed and ambition", what Raju did in the race to be among the top IT companies was not merely to blend hype with reality but turn a blind eye to accounting frauds and, worse still, siphon off huge sums. His abiding interest in promoting and strengthening Maytas Infra, managed by elder son Teja, and the closely-held Maytas Properties with a land bank of 6,800 acres, managed by younger son Rama, has cost him dear. Whether it was that, the cash crunch while sitting on a land bank or the police complaint of investor Leena Mangat who lost Rs 2 lakh after the corporate fraud was declared, or all of it together, Ramalinga is just another criminal in jail. "He is very focused and dreamt big. But the appetite for taking heavy risks also made him pay a big price," said his brother-in-law Chinta Srinivasa Raju, who was on Satyam's board from 1990 to 2000 when he quit as executive director of the company. The poker-faced Raju who started out in a NE 118 when he launched Satyam Computers and drove a black BMW till nemesis caught up with him, now faces disgrace and shame as he looks ahead to a long spell in jail, with plenty of time to reflect on his fall from grace.